

## 1. PURPOSE

The purpose of this procedure is to establish and maintain a **responsible, effective, impartial, transparent, non-discriminatory and documented system** for receiving, recording, acknowledging, assessing, investigating, deciding, communicating and closing complaints received by GO4AGRI Certification Pvt. Ltd.

This procedure is intended to ensure that:

- all complaints are handled in a fair, timely and consistent manner.
- the identity and rights of complainants are respected.
- complaints related to certification, certified operators, staff conduct, certification decisions, certification misuse, audit process, organic integrity, contamination, suspected non-compliance and scheme-specific irregularities are appropriately addressed.
- complaint handling is carried out in accordance with **ISO/IEC 17065 requirements**, applicable accreditation expectations, and the relevant organic certification requirements under **NPOP, EU Regulation (EU) 2018/848 and related acts, and the Canadian Organic Regime (COR)**;
- complaint investigations generate appropriate correction, corrective action, preventive action, sanctions, scope reduction, suspension, withdrawal, revoke or other follow-up actions, where justified.

## 2. SCOPE

This procedure applies to all complaints that may be received from:

- direct customers / certified clients / applicants.
- indirect customers, including customers of the certified client.
- consumers and end users of the product.
- members associated with group certification / ICS operations.
- certification scheme authorities, control authorities, competent authorities, accreditation bodies and regulatory bodies.
- other certification bodies.
- any other person or organization having legitimate grounds to complain.

This procedure covers complaints made against, including but not limited to:

- GO4AGRI operations or procedures.
- conduct of auditors, inspectors, reviewers, certification staff, committees or management.
- audit / inspection / certification processes carried out by GO4AGRI.
- impartiality, conflict of interest, ethics or professional misconduct.
- misuse of certification status, scope, claim, certificate, logo or mark.
- complaints related to certified clients or certified products.
- complaints involving non-compliance, suspicion of non-compliance, contamination, use of non-authorized substances, traceability failures or integrity concerns.
- irregularity notifications and cross-border or inter-CB investigation matters, including matters requiring handling through OFIS / relevant EU systems where applicable.
- complaints arising from group certification members and related internal control system concerns.

This procedure also applies where a complaint investigation results in certification action against a client or internal action against GO4AGRI personnel or processes.

### 3. RESPONSIBILITY

The responsibilities for complaint handling are defined as follows:

#### 3.1 Chief Executive Officer (CEO)

The CEO is responsible for ensuring that complaints are attended to until final resolution and corrective action, unless the CEO is directly involved in the subject of the complaint or has a conflict of interest.

#### 3.2 Certification Manager

The Certification Manager may perform the first level review of written complaints, arrange acknowledgement, register the complaint, appoint or recommend an investigator, coordinate collection of records, and support closure actions.

#### 3.3 Quality Manager

The Quality Manager may support complaint evaluation, root cause analysis, corrective action planning, review of effectiveness, and escalation where required.

#### 3.4 Investigator / Investigation Team

The appointed investigator or investigation team is responsible for carrying out a fair, technically sound and impartial investigation and submitting the findings for decision.

#### 3.5 Certification Committee / Appointed Independent Persons

If the complaint is against the CEO, or if the CEO has a conflict of interest, the Certification Committee or appointed independent personnel shall manage the investigation and decision process.

#### 3.6 All Personnel

All personnel shall cooperate in complaint investigations, provide truthful records and evidence, maintain confidentiality, and avoid influencing the complaint resolution process where they be involved in the complaint subject.

### 4. PRINCIPLES OF COMPLAINT HANDLING

GO4AGRI shall ensure that complaint handling is:

- impartial,
- transparent,
- non-discriminatory,
- documented,
- technically competent,
- completed within a defined timeframe,
- free from conflict of interest,
- respectful of complainant rights and confidentiality,
- linked to correction, corrective action and preventive action where necessary.

The submission, investigation and decision on complaints shall **not result in discriminatory action** against the complainant.

## 5. TYPES AND SCOPE OF COMPLAINTS

Complaints can be made by any person or organization and may be submitted against, but are not limited to, the following:

### 5.1 Complaints Against GO4AGRI

- GO4AGRI operations or procedures,
- conduct of auditors, certification staff, certification committee members or management,
- certification procedure lapses,
- delays, communication failures, record handling failures, or procedural non-compliance,
- impartiality, conflict of interest or confidentiality issues,
- unethical conduct or breach of code of ethics.

### 5.2 Complaints Against Audit / Inspection / Certification Activities

- conduct of audits or inspections,
- non-adherence to approved certification procedures,
- inappropriate or inadequate inspection activities,
- failure to follow sampling, traceability or evaluation requirements,
- weaknesses in decision-making or sanctions handling.

### 5.3 Complaints Against Certified Clients / Operators / Products

- misuse of certification status,
- misuse of scope or logo,
- misuse of certificate or certification mark,
- non-compliance with relevant organic standards,
- suspicion of non-compliance,
- contamination or use of unauthorized products / substances,
- improper handling, storage, transport, labelling or traceability,
- complaints linked to members under grower group certification.

### 5.4 Scheme / Authority / Regulatory Complaints

- OFIS or related EU irregularity notifications where relevant,
- complaints involving control authority / competent authority / accreditation body matters,
- complaints involving inter-CB communication or contamination source tracing,
- complaints involving COR, EU, NPOP or other recognized organic standards handled by GO4AGRI.

## 6. COMPLAINT SUBMISSION REQUIREMENTS

### 6.1 Form of Complaint

Only **written complaints** shall be entertained.

A complaint may be submitted through:

- email,
- letter,
- website complaint submission,
- documented formal written submission by any other acceptable means.

## 6.2 Minimum Complaint Information

The complaint should contain, as applicable:

- name of complainant,
- address and contact details,
- organization, where relevant,
- identity of the subject of complaint,
- nature and description of the complaint,
- relevant dates,
- product / operation / certification details, if applicable,
- supporting documents or evidence.

## 6.3 Availability of Procedure

This complaint procedure shall be made available to customers or anyone interested, as required.

## 7. RECEIPT AND ACKNOWLEDGEMENT OF COMPLAINT

### 7.1 Receipt

All written complaints received by the administrative team, through the website, by email or by post shall be forwarded without delay to the responsible person handling complaints.

### 7.2 Acknowledgement

Receipt of complaint shall be acknowledged within **one working day**.

Acknowledgement may be given by:

- a signed copy of the complaint letter; or
- a reply email confirming receipt.

For complaints involving the accreditation body or equivalent sensitive matters, the CEO shall acknowledge receipt within one working day.

### 7.3 Registration

The complaint shall be entered into the complaint register maintained for the purpose.

The details regarding the complaint shall be recorded in:

- **FMO-13: Complaint Handling Form**

## 8. PRELIMINARY REVIEW OF COMPLAINT

After preliminary understanding of the nature of complaint, the responsible person shall:

- verify whether the complaint falls within GO4AGRI's scope,
- determine whether immediate containment or certification action is required,
- identify whether technical experts are needed,
- decide whether an investigator should be appointed,
- assess whether the complaint concerns,
  - GO4AGRI staff or processes,
  - a certified operator,
  - misuse of certification,
  - organic integrity / contamination,
  - inter-CB or regulatory notification issues,
  - group certification members,
  - certification mark or scope misuse.

If needed, the complainant may be called to present the issue.

## 9. APPOINTMENT OF INVESTIGATOR AND IMPARTIALITY CONTROL

After preliminary understanding, the Certification Manager or other authorized person shall appoint an investigator to investigate the complaint and submit a report.

To ensure there is no conflict of interest:

- personnel who have provided consultancy for a client, or been employed by a client, shall not be used by GO4AGRI to review or approve the resolution of a complaint for that client within **24 months** following the end of the consultancy or employment,
- if the CEO has a conflict of interest, another competent person such as the Quality Manager, Certification Manager or Inspection Manager, who is free from conflict of interest, shall investigate instead of the CEO,
- if the complaint is against the CEO, the Certification Committee shall nominate two people to enquire into the complaint in the same manner.

The investigator shall be technically competent for the subject matter and independent from the matter complained of.

## 10. DETAILED COMPLAINT INVESTIGATION

The complaint shall be investigated by studying all relevant records, documents, evidence and technical circumstances.

The investigation may include, as applicable:

- review of application, inspection, certification and sanction records,
- review of complaint history and previous non-compliances,
- interviews with complainant, client, staff or other involved parties,
- review of traceability, production, processing, transaction, transport and labelling records,
- unannounced inspection to the concerned unit / operation, if needed,
- sampling and analysis, where necessary,
- requesting and reviewing internal investigation reports from the operator,
- cooperation with other operators, control bodies, control authorities or competent authorities, including those in other countries where relevant.

Technical experts in the relevant area shall be associated with the process where required.

## 11. ROOT CAUSE ANALYSIS AND DECISION-MAKING

The CEO or other authorized independent responsible person shall evaluate the issue, review all related records and documents, and come to a decision.

Then root cause analysis shall be conducted.

A root cause analysis of the complaint shall be done and recorded in:

- **FMO-14: RCA & Decision-Making Form**

The complaint shall be evaluated based on findings of the root cause analysis.

The complainant shall be furnished, as appropriate, with a written explanation along with supporting documentation for resolution of the complaint.

For complaints related to certification procedure lapses, an in-house meeting shall be called, and the matter shall be discussed for resolution.

**12. MINIMUM CONTENT OF INVESTIGATION REPORT**

The investigation report shall record at least the following, as applicable:

1. Which control authority(-ies) and/or control body(-ies) are / were in charge of the investigation?
2. Description of cooperation between different operators and competent authority(-ies) or, where appropriate, control authority(-ies) and/or control body(-ies) involved, including in different countries where relevant.
3. Which investigation methods / procedures were used?

This may include:

- whether the operators concerned were submitted to specific control,
- whether the operator conducted and submitted an internal investigation report,
- whether an unannounced inspection was performed,
- whether samples were taken and analysed.

4. What is the outcome of the investigation?

This includes:

- results of inspections and analyses,
- whether the origin of the non-compliance / suspicion of non-compliance / other problem was clarified,
- assessment of seriousness of the matter & recording of outcomes.

5. If applicable, whether the origin of the contamination / non-compliance / suspicion of non-compliance / other problem and the responsibility of the actors were clearly identified and established.

This may include:

- whether unauthorized products were identified,
- origin of contamination,
- whether contamination occurred at the certified location,
- whether origin was supplier / transport / packaging / other source,
- whether the matter was accidental or intentional,
- communication to another relevant certification body where the contamination source is under its control,
- actions taken by GO4AGRI.

6. Whether the identified operators have been involved in other non-compliance / suspicion of non-compliance / other problem cases in the last 3 years.

These are examples, and a similar approach shall be taken for all kinds of complaints.

**13. INVESTIGATION REPORT SHALL ALSO INCLUDE MEASURES TAKEN**

The investigation report shall also include measures taken, such as:

1. What preventive and corrective measures have been taken, including with respect to distribution / circulation of the product in the Union market and third-country markets, where relevant?
2. What actions in case of non-compliance / suspicion of non-compliance / other problem were taken on the operators and/or products concerned?

This may include:

- mode of action (written form, warning, etc.),
- whether certification was limited, suspended or withdrawn,
- date of entry into force of the action,
- duration of the action,
- the control authority and/or control body that adopted and applied the action.

3. Whether additional inspections are planned at the operators concerned.
4. What other measures the control body is planning to prevent occurrence of similar cases.

## 14. COMPLAINT OUTCOMES

### 14.1 Where a Non-Conformance is Substantiated Against a Certified Client

A complaint investigation may result in actions including, but not limited to:

- asking for further corrective actions within defined timelines,
- reduction of scope,
- suspension for a defined time period and specific conditions,
- withdrawal / revoke of certification,
- other sanction as justified.

These decisions shall be communicated immediately to the client and not later than within **2 working days**.

The affected client may appeal the decision in accordance with the appeal procedure.

### 14.2 Where a Non-Conformance is Substantiated Against GO4AGRI Staff or Processes

The complaint may result in:

- revision of policies or procedures,
- retraining of staff,
- disciplinary action,
- stricter action in case of intentional or severe violation of code of ethics,
- management system corrections and corrective action.

## 15. SPECIAL SCHEME-SPECIFIC CONSIDERATIONS

| General requirements                                                                                                                                                | NPOP-specific                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | EU-specific                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | COR-specific                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Complaints shall be investigated objectively and may lead to corrective action, sanctions, scope reduction, suspension, withdrawal or internal system improvements. | Complaints related to NPOP-certified operators, misuse of India Organic status, traceability, organic integrity, or sanctioned products shall be handled under this procedure and linked with sanction controls and APEDA-related requirements where applicable. | Complaints involving EU irregularities, suspicion of non-compliance, contamination, OFIS-type notifications, cross-border cases, or Union market circulation shall be investigated with the level of detail required for EU organic control follow-up and communication through the relevant EU systems wherever necessary. | Complaints under COR shall consider SFCR, COR operating requirements, contamination origin, non-compliance seriousness, and any required action related to suspension, cancellation, reinstatement or reporting to the relevant authority / oversight framework. |

## 16. TIMELINES FOR CLOSURE

All complaints shall normally be closed within **20 working days** from the date of receipt of complaint.

Based on complexity, this may extend to **30 working days** in rare circumstances.

Where extension is necessary, the reason shall be documented, and the complainant shall be informed as appropriate.

## 17. COMMUNICATION OF DECISION

The decision shall be communicated to the complainant.

The communication shall include, as appropriate:

- the conclusion reached,
- basis of decision,
- whether corrective or preventive action has been initiated,
- whether any certification action has been taken,
- whether the complainant has a right to appeal or escalate.

If the complainant is not satisfied with the decision, they may make an appeal to the certification body or make a complaint to the accreditation body within **30 days** of the decision.

## 18. RECORDS AND RECORD RETENTION

The details regarding complaints and their resolution shall be maintained in controlled records.

Relevant records include:

- **FMO-13: Complaint Handling Form**
- **FMO-14: RCA & Decision-Making Form**
- Complaint Register
- complaint acknowledgement records
- investigation reports
- supporting documents and evidence
- sampling / analysis records, where applicable
- internal investigation reports, where applicable
- sanction / scope reduction / suspension / withdrawal records arising from complaint
- communication records with complainant, client, authority or other CB, where applicable
- records of corrective action and preventive action

All complaint-related records shall be maintained as per:

- **PRO-01: Document Control Procedure**

## 19. LINKAGES WITH OTHER PROCEDURES

This procedure shall be read together with, as applicable:

- **PRO-01: Document Control Procedure**
- **PRO-02: Integrity, Confidentiality & Conflict of Interest Procedure**
- **PRO-05: Appeal Procedure**
- **PRO-10: Inspection Procedure**
- **PRO-18: applicable sanction catalogue procedures / Catalogue of Measures (EU)**
- procedures for suspension, withdrawal, cancellation, revoke and related certification actions
- procedures for follow-up on positive residue / contamination cases, where applicable

## 20. PRECEDENCE RULE

Where any conflict exists between this procedure and the applicable scheme requirements, regulation, operating manual, accreditation criteria or competent authority instructions, the **applicable normative requirements shall prevail**.



## 21. RECORD REFERENCES

For control and traceability, the main pertaining records and linked references under this procedure are:

| Record / Reference                                 | Purpose / Use                                                                            |
|----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>FMO-13: Complaint Handling Form</b>             | Recording complaint details, subject, source, classification and handling status         |
| <b>FMO-14: RCA &amp; Decision-Making Form</b>      | Root cause analysis, decision basis, correction, corrective action and preventive action |
| <b>Complaint Register</b>                          | Registration and tracking of complaints from receipt to closure                          |
| <b>Complaint acknowledgement record</b>            | Evidence of receipt and response within defined timeline                                 |
| <b>Investigation report</b>                        | Formal technical record of investigation process, findings and outcome                   |
| <b>Internal investigation report from operator</b> | Used where operator is asked to investigate and submit findings                          |
| <b>Inspection / unannounced inspection records</b> | Evidence used in investigating complaint, where applicable                               |
| <b>Sampling and analysis records</b>               | Used where complaint requires laboratory verification                                    |
| <b>Sanction / certification action records</b>     | Evidence of reduction of scope, suspension, withdrawal, revoke or related action         |
| <b>Communication records</b>                       | Evidence of communication with complainant, operator, authority or other CB              |
| <b>PRO-01</b>                                      | Record control and retention                                                             |
| <b>PRO-02</b>                                      | Impartiality and conflict of interest safeguards                                         |
| <b>PRO-05</b>                                      | Appeal route where complainant / client is dissatisfied                                  |
| <b>PRO-18 Applicable sanction procedures</b>       | Decision framework for substantiated non-compliance                                      |